Product launches.
Make the moment matter.

A practical framework for PMMs and Product Managers to tier launches, group releases, and plan who hears what, when.



Ship at the pace the product needs. Communicate at the pace customers can use. Launch when you have a story worth their attention.

Read the method. Work through the six questions with your PM. Use the workbook to record the evidence and agree the decision.

Independent practical synthesis. Tiering foundations are credited to Intercom, Appcues, and Ready for Launch. Edition 3 · October 2026.

Make the choice before the plan.

Start with the customer's job and the commercial opportunity. Leave the asset list for later.

01 / Tier it

How much does it matter? Name who values the change, what they can do, and how that could affect acquisition, expansion, retention, or adoption.

02 / Group it

Is it stronger together? Look for releases that let the same audience complete a more valuable job. A shared date is not enough.

03 / Sequence it

Who needs what, when? Separate product availability, customer preparation, and the market moment.

> A launch tier is a resource decision. Customer preparation is an impact decision. A quiet release can still need serious preparation.

Bring two perspectives to the decision

Product: customer job, capability, dependencies, quality, and availability.
PMM: buying reason, evidence, alternatives, narrative, and audience timing.
Together: agree the tier, path, owner, and open questions.

Give the right change the right attention.

Use these tiers as starting points. Record why your launch belongs there.

P0 / Scream

A new product, market, or buying case changes the GTM.

Dedicated strategy and a coordinated market moment.

P1 / Shout

A strong reason to choose, expand, or reconsider for a defined audience.

Focused story, proof, field enablement, and adoption support.

P2 / Cheer

An existing job gets meaningfully easier.

Targeted education, documentation, and relevant field updates.

P3 / Whisper

A small improvement or fix matters to affected users.

Release notes and contextual guidance, with preparation scaled to impact.

P0–P3 follow my original template. Other frameworks use different labels. A parity feature can deserve P1 when it removes a major blocker; novelty alone does not set the tier.

Group the outcome. Then test the promise.

A collection earns more investment when its combined value changes the buying case.

Same audience

Are the releases valuable to the same people in the same situation?

Connected job

Do the capabilities work together to make a meaningful job possible or easier?

Stronger buying reason

Does the collection change the reason to buy, expand, renew, or adopt?

Credible availability

Can customers access the parts required for the stated outcome?

A clear headline

Can you explain the outcome in one sentence without listing features?

> If removing a feature leaves the story clearer, it may belong in a release note rather than the headline.

Intercom's 2019 guidance already described grouping, impact, and targeting. This playbook applies those principles through a shared PMM–PM decision and audience plan.

One plan.
Different moments.

What customers need next and what the market needs to understand are different jobs.

Product / What can people access?

Confirm cohorts, dates, packaging, dependencies, and support. Separate available capability from planned additions.

Customers / What do they need to do?

Prepare admins before setup or permission changes. Help users when they have access. Explain expansion value to the relevant buyers.

Market / Why should they reconsider?

Connect the capabilities to an important outcome and credible difference. Launch when availability and proof support the story.

Batch the market story. Keep customer guidance timely.
Never hold back material change information or useful guidance while waiting for a campaign date.

When something slips

Narrow the promise, change the audience, or move the moment. If you show a future direction, say what is available now, what comes later, and what the outcome depends on.

AI changes the pace. Keep the buying reason clear.

More output makes deliberate choices and accurate product promises more valuable.

The pressure is visible

In a September 2026 Appcues × Navattic survey, 75% reported faster shipping and 7% said their launch process kept up. The sample was 60 marketers through vendor networks: a directional signal, not a universal benchmark or proof that AI caused the acceleration.

Make AI earn its place

Explain the task, the change in how work gets done, and why the audience values it. The technology label does not raise the tier.

Connect tomorrow to today

Give buyers a credible direction and value they can access now. Check the alternatives they actually consider, including tools they already own.

Keep the promise current

Use AI to flag affected messaging and assets when product facts change. Product verifies the capability; PMM owns the interpretation. For AI actions, check outcomes, limits, and human input.

April Dunford's May 2026 positioning guidance informs the actual-alternatives and future-to-present lens. Anthropic's agent evaluation guidance informs outcome checks. These launch applications are my interpretation.

Pressure-test the awkward cases.

Use these fictional situations to calibrate the team's judgment.

A collection

A connector, mobile access, and an approved action ship separately. Customers receive guidance at each stage. The wider market hears the complete workflow story once it is available and proven. Tier the combined outcome.

A buying blocker

An identity integration is familiar in the category but essential to a valuable segment. Deal evidence supports a targeted P1 investment. A capability can change the buying case without being new to the market.

An AI behaviour change

An assistant can now take an action after confirmation. Promotion may stay quiet, while administrators and users need clear preparation on permissions, responsibility, and recovery.

Ask your PM: would we make the same investment if this feature had a less exciting name?

Public observation: Fin 4 presents several developments through a broader customer-experience direction. That illustrates a connected market story; it does not establish internal planning, rollout timing, or results.

Make the decision easy to use again.

Use the workbook in a 25-minute release review. Bring evidence, not a finished campaign.

Before / Bring the inputs

A short list of releases, the customer problem, availability and dependencies, customer or deal signals, and the actual alternatives.

Minutes 0–8 / Establish the value

Work through the six diagnostic questions. Separate what you know from what you assume. Agree the provisional tier.

Minutes 8–16 / Test the collection

Map related releases to one audience and outcome. Keep unrelated changes separate. Confirm what a slipped dependency would change.

Minutes 16–25 / Agree the audience plan

Decide what admins, users, buyers, the field, and the market need. Assign an owner, open questions, and a review trigger.

> End with a decision you can explain: tier, collection or individual path, audience timing, preparation, owner, and unresolved evidence.

After launch, check eligible reach, first value, repeat use, and the relevant commercial goal. Choose a review window that fits the usage and buying cycle. Use what you learn to improve the next decision.

A quieter launch. Clear customer responsibilities.

Make these decisions for every customer-facing release, whatever the promotional tier.

Accurate product facts

Check what changed, eligible access, price, dependencies, and limitations. Update affected claims. A recorded no-change decision is valid when nothing needs updating.

Affected audiences

Name the administrators, users, account buyers, and field teams who need to know. Choose relevant channels; a blanket announcement is not the default.

A route to value

Assign the setup, education, and support the change requires. A note may be enough for a small improvement; a workflow change may need more.

Follow-through

Name the owner, evidence of first value, and a review window that fits the job. Keep the effort proportionate to the release.

> A quieter launch should still leave customers knowing what changed and how to benefit.

In the Appcues × Navattic survey, 60% reported falling behind on customer education and 59% on Sales/CS enablement. Read the source. September 2026; 60 marketers through vendor networks; question bases vary. Directional, self-reported findings. The minimum standard above is my application.

Agree the handoff before the scramble.

Set a working agreement with Product once, then revisit it when the release process changes.

Which changes need a heads-up?

Define customer-facing changes: capability, access, packaging, permissions, and material behaviour changes.

When and where does PMM hear?

Choose the shared release record and handoff event. Involve PMM before customer access or commitments are fixed when preparation is needed.

What does Product supply?

Customer job, scope, eligible cohort, availability, dependencies, limitations, and owner. Mark unknowns.

What happens when plans change?

Name who flags changes in timing, scope, access, or claims. Identify the communication and enablement owners who review their impact.

Who owns the audiences and decision?

Assign customer guidance, field readiness, market communication, and the decision to proceed, narrow, or delay. PMM is not the automatic owner of every task.

Appcues × Navattic reported that 56% heard about releases close to launch or after the fact. Read the source. September 2026; 60 marketers through vendor networks; question bases vary. The agreement is a recommended response, not a process tested by the survey.

Locate the gap.
Choose the next conversation.

Review one eligible cohort and one time window. Fit the measures to the customer's job.

01 / Eligible

Who can use it? Check plan, cohort, rollout, configuration, and permissions. Exclude people without access from the adoption denominator.

02 / Aware

Did useful guidance reach them? Delivery or in-product exposure can indicate reach. Test understanding separately where it matters.

03 / Tried

Did they attempt the supported workflow? An announcement click is not necessarily a product attempt. Investigate setup, relevance, and confidence.

04 / Reached value

Did the job complete successfully? Account for correction effort and exceptions. A generated answer is not automatically a completed outcome.

05 / Returned

Did they use it successfully when the need recurred? A rare job does not need daily activity to be valuable.

> The next step follows the gap: fix access, improve reach, clarify the use case, resolve product friction, or investigate recurring need.

A diagnostic sequence, not a guaranteed linear funnel or a validated predictive model. Exposure is not proof of understanding. Track the relevant commercial goal against its own baseline.

Use AI to maintain what the launch depends on.

Start with an approved product change and one set of dependent assets.

01 / Source change

Product records capability, eligibility, availability, limits, and the change owner in the shared product record.

02 / Find the impact

AI compares that record with mapped claims, decks, demos, help content, and customer guidance. Preserve source references.

03 / Propose edits

Show the proposed change and its reason. Keep permissions, scope, and availability qualifiers.

04 / Human review

Product verifies facts. PMM approves the message. Enablement, support, and channel owners review their own material.

05 / Refresh

Owners publish approved updates, link them to the source version, and record the next review trigger.

Fictional example: a search connector gains a confirmed request action for named pilot accounts. Flag the search-only slide, missing help instructions, and demo implying general availability. A scoped draft says: “Pilot users can submit supported requests after confirmation.” Verify facts and update the dependent assets.

Proposed workflow, not a claim that an integration or automatic update is running. Begin with one shared document and the assistant your team already uses.

Sources and influences.

Credit the foundations. Be clear about the extensions and the limits of the evidence.

Intercom / Matt Hodges · Prioritising product announcements

The foundation: give different releases different levels of attention.

Intercom / Jasmine Jaume · How to evolve product launches as you grow

Impact-led tiering, grouping related releases, and targeted communication. Grouping is an established practice, not an invention of this playbook.

Ready for Launch / PMM Course Crew · The course I took

Andy McCotter-Bicknell, Jason Oakley, and Tamara Grominsky. Research, segmentation, positioning, tiering, GTM themes, execution, and enablement. Referenced from the public syllabus; course materials are not reproduced here.

Appcues · Launch framework

A practical influence on my original tiering template and its launch motions. Labels and tier numbering vary between frameworks.

April Dunford / May 2026 · Positioning in the Age of AI

Position against the alternatives buyers actually consider. Connect a credible future direction to value customers can buy today. This is positioning guidance, not a launch-tiering framework.

Appcues × Navattic / September 2026 · State of Product Launches 2026

September 2026 survey of 60 marketers through vendor networks. Selected findings cover shipping pace, customer education, Sales/CS enablement, and late release visibility. Question bases vary; self-reported, directional evidence, not proof of AI causation.

Fin / October 2026 · Introducing Fin 4

A public example of several product developments presented through a broader customer-experience direction. It does not reveal internal tiering, release dates, or launch effectiveness.

Anthropic / January 2026 · Demystifying evals for AI agents

Engineering guidance on evaluating outcomes and monitoring changes. Applying those lessons to launch claims is my PMM interpretation.

Your decision guide.

One page to keep beside the roadmap. Use with your PM before committing GTM effort.

01 / What changes?

Name the customer outcome and commercial consequence. Choose a provisional tier: P0 changed GTM; P1 buying reason or blocker; P2 an easier existing job; P3 small improvement.

02 / Who values it?

Identify the audience and evidence. Unknown value makes the choice provisional. A focused segment can justify meaningful investment.

03 / Is it stronger together?

Same audience, connected job, stronger outcome. Group when those hold; keep coincidental releases separate.

04 / Does timing support the story?

Guide customers as parts ship. Announce the complete outcome when the essential parts are available. Keep uncertain dates provisional.

05 / What must customers do?

Scale preparation to learning, setup, permissions, or workflow change. This does not automatically change promotional intensity.

06 / Can we support the promise?

Check scope, availability, price, limits, demonstration, and evidence. Narrow claims or resolve gaps before promotion.

Agree: tier · grouping · audience timing · preparation · owner · review trigger. Override the diagnostic when evidence supports it, and write down why. The tier is a judgment, not an approval or prediction.